VOTES THAT COUNT

The communities that have the numbers to swing the polls

PATIDARS: They make up 18-19 per cent of the vote, and have influence in 40 seats. Largely a farming community, the Patidars also have a presence among the urban middle class and powerful non-resident Gujaratis. They do not vote as a bloc, though. The BJP suffered due to the 2017 Patidar agitation but now has the face of the strike, Hardik Patel, in their ranks. CM Bhupendrabhai Patel is also a Patidar. AAP state convenor Gopal Italia was an active participant in the 2017 agitation

OBC: Comprising over 140 communities, OBCs make up 52 per cent of Gujarat's population. Koli and Thakor are the two dominant communities that influence seats in Saurashtra and north Gujarat respectively. Congress president Jagdish Thakor and AAP general secretary Isudan Gadhvi are OBCs. BJP faces discontent among a section of the OBCs as two of their leaders—Congress turncoats Kunwarji Bawaliya and Jawahar Chavda—who had been made ministers were dropped from the new cabinet last year

DALITS: They make up about 8 per cent of the population; 13 seats are reserved for the SCs and they can affect the result in another 12-15 seats. The Congress is banking on Jignesh Mevani to bring in their votes after losing its Dalit strongman, Pravin Maru, to the BJP in 2020. AAP is appealing to Dalit voters by invoking Ambedkar

MUSLIMS: Some 9-10 per cent of the population, Muslim votes can influence 35-38 seats but have so far been divided between the Congress and Independent candidates. This year, an upset is likely owing to the BJP outreach to Pasmanda Muslims. AIMIM is a strong contender to win the two Muslim-dominated seats held now by the Congress. In the other seats, it may eat into Congress votes. AAP is making no overt effort to woo the Muslims

TRIBALS: Twenty-seven seats are reserved for STs, who account for 15 per cent of the state's population. While tribal president Droupadi Murmu will be one of the BJP's trump cards to get their votes, the party is on the back foot over the tribal agitation against the Par Tapi Narmada Link project. This is why two of the BJP's five Gaurav Yatra routes were dedicated to tribal-dominated seats. The two MLA-strong Bharatiya Tribal Party (BTP), led by Chhotu Vasava, ended a short tie-up with AAP recently and is most likely to reconcile with the Congress

year, farmers had protested against inadequate power supply, low remuneration for certain crops and also demanded a minimum support price for salt. The widespread losses to the dairy sector due to lumpy skin disease—Gujarat has lost nearly 6,000 cattle to the outbreak—has added to the party's concerns. To create awareness among farmers about the benefits of state and central schemes, audio-visual screens have been put across the state displaying their details.

Meanwhile, state employees are demanding a return to the old pension scheme as the new system doesn't guarantee a secure monthly income. The Congress has been trying to corner the BJP on the issue. "We are in touch with the unions and have promised to revert to the old pension scheme as we have done in Rajasthan and Chhattisgarh," says party spokesperson Manish Doshi. There is also the small matter of factionalism, with a cold war brewing between CM Patel and state BJP president C.R. Patil.

Aware of these internal tensions, Modi himself has taken charge of the poll campaign. It's the only state now where the BJP has no observer for political affairs or to oversee poll preparations. The *pravasi* teams—headed by ministers and MPs—anchoring organisational work and electoral management report directly to the PM. Even Shah is playing second fiddle as are Union ministers from the state such as Parshottam Rupala and Mansukh Mandaviya. Yet, Shah spends at least three days a week touring Gujarat, ironing out dissidence and differences in local communities.

The RSS state unit is also working directly with the PM. For the past two years, Sangh affiliates have had a number of outreach programmes to woo the tribal and Dalit groups. In fact, two routes of the Gaurav Yatra were dedicated to tribal seats. Recently, CM Patel, under pressure from agitating tribal groups, announced that the state was scrapping the Par Tapi Narmada Link project, which had proposed to transfer water from surplus regions in the Western Ghats to arid Saurashtra and Kutch in Gujarat. The Congress, however, has attacked the government saying it's a false promise as the state doesn't have the authority to roll back a scheme announced in the Union budget.

But with Patel as CM, the saffron party hopes to win back the support of the influential Patidar community. The Patidar agitation in 2017 demanding OBC reservation had hit the BJP, but this time the face of the protests, Hardik Patel, is in their camp. Meanwhile, Naresh Patel, an extremely influential personality among the Leuva Patels, is reportedly in touch with Modi through Union minister Rupala and C.R. Patil.

THE AAP CHALLENGE

Much as the BJP and Congress leaders dismiss AAP this election, there is a palpable feeling that the Kejriwal-led party could prove a major disrupter. After a dismal performance last election, AAP is expected to dent the Congress's chances in rural seats, while in the 55-odd urban seats, it's the BJP that may suffer. It's perhaps why the Congress is focusing more on rural areas in the belief that a fierce AAP-BJP contest in